Anomaly detection using surprisals

Rob J Hyndman
Department of Econometrics & Business Statistics
Monash University
Clayton 3800
Australia
Email: Rob.Hyndman@monash.edu
Corresponding author

David T Frazier
Department of Econometrics & Business Statistics
Monash University
Clayton 3800
Australia

9 October 2025

JEL classification: C10,C14,C46

Anomaly detection using surprisals

Abstract

TBC

Keywords: Extreme value theory; Generalized Pareto Distribution; Outlier detection; Tail bounds.

1 Introduction

Anomaly detection methods are often rather ad hoc and lack a solid theoretical foundation, or they make strong distributional assumptions that may not hold in practice. We aim to address this by defining an anomaly as a point of low probability, and proposing a general framework for anomaly detection by estimating the probability of each observation, or one more anomalous. Our approach allows for a unified treatment of anomaly detection that can be applied to any anomaly detection problem, provided a probability distribution can be defined on the space of observations. It allows for univariate and multivariate settings, and can be applied to both unconditional and conditional distributions. Although it requires a specified probability distribution, it is robust to substantial mis-specification of that distribution.

The basic idea is to calculate the surprisal (equal to the negative log density) of each observation, and then estimate the tail probability from the surprisal distribution. This allows us to estimate the probability of observing a surprisal value as extreme or more extreme than a given observation, which can then be used to flag anomalies. The surprisal approach to anomaly detection provides a principled way to control the false positive rate when flagging anomalies, by setting a threshold on the estimated tail probabilities.

Let $\boldsymbol{y}_1, \ldots, \boldsymbol{y}_n$ be iid observations from a probability distribution F defined on an appropriate sample space, and let f be the generalized probability density function of F. That is, f is defined using Dirac delta functions at jump points of F, so that it represents the density function if F is continuous, the probability mass function if F is discrete, and a combination of both if F is a mixture of continuous and discrete components.

The *surprisal* of observation $\boldsymbol{y}_i$ is defined as (Stone 2022)

$$s_i = -\log f(\boldsymbol{y}_i).$$

While these are better known as "log scores" in statistics (Good 1952), in this context we prefer the term "surprisal" (coined by Tribus 1961), as it captures the idea that observations with low density are more "surprising" (and therefore potentially anomalous) than those with high density. A large value of s_i indicates that $\boldsymbol{y}_i$ is an unlikely value, and so is a potential anomaly. On the other hand, typical values will have low surprisals. In information theory, the average surprisal is known as the entropy of a random variable (Cover & Thomas 2006; Stone 2022) and provides a measure of uncertainty. If f is obtained from a parametric model, then the sum of the surprisals is equal to minus the log likelihood of the data.

Let $G(s) = \Pr\{S \leq s\}$ be the distribution function of the surprisal values, where $S = -\log f(\boldsymbol{Y})$ and $\boldsymbol{Y} \sim F$. Then the probability of observing a value with surprisal at least as large as s is given by $1 - G(s)$, which leads to a natural way of assigning an anomaly score to each observation $\boldsymbol{y}_i$:

$$p_i = 1 - G(s_i) = 1 - G(-\log f(\boldsymbol{y}_i)).$$

We define anomalies as observations with $p_i < \alpha$, giving a false positive rate of α if all observations are from F. This is preferable to directly computing the probabilities from the tail of F, as it allows for anomalies to occur anywhere in the distribution of F, not just in its tails. For example, anomalies may lie between modes in a multimodal distribution, or in otherwise low-density regions of the distribution F. It is also preferable to a distance-based approach to anomaly detection (e.g., Wilkinson 2018), as it naturally handles skewed and heavy-tailed distributions.

The surprisal approach converts the problem of working with F, a potentially multivariate distribution (or even one on a manifold or some non-Euclidean space), to working with a univariate distribution G defined on $\mathbb{R}$. We can write

$$G(s) = \Pr\{-\log f(\boldsymbol{Y}) \leq s\} = \Pr\{f(\boldsymbol{Y}) \geq e^{-s}\}.$$

This makes clear that the surprisal probability is related to the highest density regions of the distribution (Hyndman 1996). In fact, every observation with $p_i < \alpha$ lies outside the $100(1-\alpha)\%$ highest density region of F.

If $F = N(\mu, \sigma^2)$, then $p_i = 2[1 - \Phi(|y_i - \mu|/\sigma)]$, where Φ is the standard Normal distribution function. In this case, identifying anomalies as observations with $p_i < \alpha$ is equivalent to a z-score test with the threshold set to $\Phi^{-1}(1-\alpha/2)$.Hence, our approach can be seen as a generalization of anomaly detection methods based on z-scores including Grubbs' test (Grubbs 1950).

It can also be seen as a generalization of other anomaly detection methods. For example, the Hampel identifier, due to a proposal of Frank Hampel (Davies & Gather 1993), is designed to identify anomalies in a time series based on whether an observation is very different from the neighboring observations. It denotes an observation as an anomaly if $|y_t - m_t|/a_t > \tau$, where

$$\begin{aligned} m_t &= \text{median}(y_{t-h}, \dots, y_{t+h}), \\ \text{and} \qquad a_t &= \text{median}(|y_{t-h} - m_t|, \dots, |y_{t+h} - m_t|). \end{aligned}$$

The threshold τ is often set under the assumption of a Normal distribution. When we take a surprisal perspective, this is equivalent to setting

$$F = N(m_t, a_t/\Phi^{-1}(0.75)).$$

The false anomaly rate is $\alpha = 2[1 - \Phi(\tau\Phi(0.75))]$.

We will usually not know F, and so we need to estimate it from data or from theory. Such estimates are particularly fragile or uncertain in areas of low density, which is precisely where we are looking for anomalies. Further, we are seeking a method that does not make strong distributional assumptions.

Our approach begins with an assumed F, which may be estimated from data, or obtained from theory. This distribution is used to compute the surprisal values $\{s_1, \dots, s_n\}$. Then, we estimate the tail probabilities $\{p_1, \dots, p_n\}$ from the surprisal values, using one of three approaches.

(1) Using the assumed distribution F to compute the tail probabilities, i.e., $p_i = \int I\{f(\boldsymbol{y}) \le e^{-s_i}\} d\boldsymbol{y}$, where I is the indicator function;
(2) Using the empirical distribution function of the observed surprisals $\{s_1, \dots, s_n\}$, so that p_i is the proportion of surprisals at least as large as s_i;
(3) Fitting a Generalized Pareto Distribution (GPD) to the largest surprisal values, and using this to estimate the tail probabilities.

Obviously approach (1) makes the strong assumption that F is an accurate representation of the data. Approaches (2) and (3) allow for considerable mis-specification of the distribution used to compute the surprisals. Approach (2) requires only that the ordering of the surprisals in the tail is similar to what would have been obtained under the true distribution, while approach (3) requires that extreme value theory applies to the surprisal distribution.

We illustrate the three approaches with several examples, including both simulated and real data.

> **Note**
>
> Outline of paper TBC

2 Empirical surprisal probabilities

Under approach (2) above, we estimate p_i as the proportion of surprisals larger than s_i. For large n, this provides a quick and convenient estimate of p_i that is accurate even when the assumed distribution F is not.

> **Important**
>
> What can we say about the quality of the approximation?
>
> If the surprisal ranks under the true and estimated F distributions are equal, this is obviously ok.
>
> That should be true in the tails of any distribution — i.e., when y_i is greater than the largest mode of f, or less than the smallest mode of f.
>
> Can we say anything else?

Using this approach, the anomaly boundary for a threshold of α corresponds to the $100(1-\alpha)\%$ highest density region computed using the quantile density approach of Hyndman (1996).

3 Extreme value theory for the surprisal distribution

Our third approach uses extreme value theory applied to the surprisal values. We will show that under weak conditions on the tail of the surprisal distribution, the maximum surprisal converges to one of the three types of extreme value distributions. This justifies fitting a Generalized Pareto Distribution (GPD) to the largest surprisal values, and using it to estimate tail probabilities.

An important precursor to this work is Kandanaarachchi & Hyndman (2022) who proposed estimating F by a leave-one-out kernel density estimate, and then fitting a Generalized Pareto Distribution (GPD) to the most extreme surprisal values. The underlying idea is that even if F is not particularly well-estimated, the tail of the surprisal distribution should still be well-approximated by a GPD. Hyndman, Kandanaarachchi & Turner (2025) provides some theoretical justification for this approach in the context of kernel density estimation.

Here we extend that idea to allow F to be any well-behaved distribution, including conditional distributions. Specifically, we fit a GPD to the largest β of $\{s_i\}_{i=1}^n$, obtaining estimates of the location, scale and shape parameters, (μ, σ, ξ). We calculate the probability of each observation or one more

extreme, $p_i = \beta\left[1 - P(s_i \mid \hat{\mu}, \hat{\sigma}, \hat{\xi})\right]$, where P is the distribution function of the GPD. Observations not contained in the largest β of $\{s_i\}_{i=1}^n$ are assigned $p_i = \beta$. To justify this approach, we seek conditions on the surprisal distribution of $S = -\log f(\boldsymbol{Y})$, where $\boldsymbol{Y} \sim F$, similar to the Fisher-Tippett-Gnedenko (FTG) theorem (Coles 2001).

We consider three possible conditions on the surprisal distribution of $S = -\log f(\boldsymbol{Y})$ where f is the density of $\boldsymbol{Y}$. These conditions describe increasingly heavy tails:

1. where S is sub-Gaussian (e.g., when f is bounded above and below);
2. where S is sub-exponential (e.g., when f is Gaussian); and
3. where S has a polynomial moment (e.g., when f is Student-t).

We state these as three alternative assumptions.

Assumption 3.1 (Sub-Gaussian)**.** The random variable $S = -\log f(Y) \in \mathbb{R}$, and satisfies, for all $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$, and some $\nu > 0$,

$$\mathbb{E}\exp\{\lambda(S - \mathbb{E}[S])\} \leq \exp\{\lambda^2\nu^2/2\}.$$

Assumption 3.2 (Sub-exponential)**.** The random variable S is sub-exponential with parameters ν and b, i.e.,

$$\mathbb{E}\exp\{\lambda(S - \mathbb{E}[S])\} \leq \exp\{\lambda^2\nu^2/2\} \quad \text{for all} \quad |\lambda| < 1/b.$$

Assumption 3.3 (Polynomial)**.** The random variable $|S|$ has polynomial moments of order $\alpha \geq 1$; i.e., $\mathbb{E}[|S|^p] \leq C^p$ for some $C > 0$ such that $C^p - 1 > 0$.

Under each of Assumptions 3.1–3.3, we seek a result on the limiting distribution of the maximum of the surprisals $M_n = \max\{s_1, \ldots, s_n\}$. If we can show that this distribution falls within the class of extreme value distributions, then we can fit a Generalized Pareto Distribution (GPD) to the largest surprisal values (Coles 2001).

3.1 S has sub-Gaussian tails

Let's first assume that the surprisals are well-behaved and have a sub-Gaussian tail. Assumption 3.1 will be satisfied in cases where the density f is bounded both above and below, such as with mass functions on a finite set. However, it may not be satisfied if the log density has no lower bound.

For example, consider the truncated normal distribution on $[a, b]$, where $Y \sim TN(a, b, \mu, \sigma^2)$ and $-\infty < a < b < \infty$. Then

$$S = -\log(2\pi\sigma^2)/2 - \frac{1}{2\sigma^2}(Y - \mu)^2 - \log\{\Phi(b) - \Phi(a)\},$$

where Φ is the standard normal distribution function. Since $Y \in [a,b]$, S is bounded for all $\sigma > 0$ and hence S satisfies Assumption 3.1.

Under Assumption 3.1, we have the following result on the maximum of the surprisals.

Lemma 3.1. *Suppose $\boldsymbol{y}_1, \dots, \boldsymbol{y}_n$ are iid from a density f, and let $M_n = \max\{s_1, \dots, s_n\}$ where $s_i = -\log f(\boldsymbol{y}_i)$. If $S = -\log f(Y) \in \mathbb{R}$, and satisfies, for all $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$, and some $\nu > 0$,*

$$\mathbb{E}\exp\{\lambda(S - \mathbb{E}[S])\} \le \exp\{\lambda^2\nu^2/2\},$$

, then, for $s \in \mathbb{R}_+$,

$$\Pr\{M_n - \mathbb{E}[S] \ge s\} \le 1 - \left(1 - e^{-\frac{1}{2}s^2/\nu^2}\right)^n.$$

Proof. For any $\lambda > 0$,

$$\begin{aligned}\Pr\{S \ge s\} = \Pr\left\{e^{\lambda(S-\mathbb{E}[S])} \ge e^{\lambda(s-\mathbb{E}[S])}\right\} &\le e^{-\lambda(s-\mu)}\mathbb{E}e^{\lambda(S-\mu)} \\ &\le e^{-\lambda(s-\mu)}e^{\lambda^2\nu^2/2}.\end{aligned}$$

Now, we can maximize the right-hand side of the above bound in λ, which yields the optimal value $\lambda = (s-\mu)/\{M^2\}$. Plugging this in we have the bound

$$\Pr\{S \ge s\} \le e^{-\frac{1}{2}(s-\mu)^2/\nu^2}.$$

The stated result now follows by noting that

$$\begin{aligned}\Pr(M_n - \mathbb{E}[S] \ge s) = 1 - \Pr\{M_n \le s\} &= 1 - \Pr\{S \le s\}^n \\ &= 1 - (1 - \Pr\{S \ge s\})^n \\ &\le 1 - \left(1 - e^{-\frac{1}{2}s^2/\nu^2}\right)^n.\end{aligned}$$

□

Corollary 3.1. *If Assumption 3.1 is satisfied, then, for all $s > 0$,*

$$\Pr\left(|M_n - \mathbb{E}[S]| \ge \sqrt{2\nu^2 s} + \sqrt{2\nu^2\log(2n)}\right) \le e^{-s}.$$

Proof. This follows directly from the union bound:

$$\Pr\left(|M_n| \ge \sqrt{2\nu^2 s} + \sqrt{2\nu^2\log(n)}\right) \le n\Pr\left\{|S| \ge \sqrt{2}\nu^2 s + \sqrt{2\nu^2\log(n)}\right\}$$

$$
\begin{aligned}
&\leq 2ne^{-[\sqrt{2\nu^2 s}+\sqrt{2\nu^2\log(n)}]^2/(2\nu^2)} \\
&= 2ne^{-\frac{1}{2\nu^2}(2s\nu^2)-\frac{2\nu^2\log(2n)}{2\nu^2}-\frac{\sqrt{2\nu^2 s}\sqrt{2\nu^2\log(2n)}}{2\nu^2}} \\
&\leq e^{-\sqrt{\log(2n)s}-s} \\
&\leq e^{-s}
\end{aligned}
$$

The first result follows from the iid assumption on S and the union bound, while the second from the assumption that S is sub-Gaussian. The remaining inequalities follow from reorganizing terms. □

Corollary 3.1 is useful as it clarifies that if the surprisal is sub-Gaussian, then the maximal surprisal will follow a reversed Weibull distribution, and thus is within the class of extreme value distributions.

3.2 S has an exponential moment

In cases where the underlying density has full support on $\mathbb{R}$ and the log density cannot be bounded from below, then the sub-Gaussianity condition in Assumption 3.1 may be violated, as the following result illustrates.

Lemma 3.2. *If $Y \sim N(\mu, \sigma^2)$, then $S = -\log f(Y)$ is sub-exponential. In particular,*

$$\mathbb{E}e^{\lambda(S-1/2)+(\lambda/2)\log(2\pi\sigma^2)} \leq e^{\lambda^2/2+(\lambda/2)\log(2\pi\sigma^2)}, \quad \forall|\lambda| < 1/2.$$

Proof. Firstly, note that

$$S = -\log f(Y) = \frac{1}{2}\log(2\pi\sigma^2) + \frac{(Y-\mu)^2}{2\sigma^2}.$$

and that

$$\mu_S = \mathbb{E}[S] = -\int f(y)\log f(y)\mathrm{d}y = \frac{1}{2}\{1+\log(2\pi\sigma^2)\}.$$

Define

$$X = \frac{1}{2}\frac{(Y-\mu)^2}{\sigma^2} - \frac{1}{2},$$

then $\mathbb{E}[X] = 0$. Now, note that

$$\mathbb{E}e^{\frac{\lambda}{2}(S-1)} = e^{\lambda/2\{\log(2\pi\sigma^2)\}}\frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi\sigma^2}}\int e^{\frac{\lambda}{2}\left[\frac{(y-\mu)^2}{\sigma^2}-1\right]}e^{-\frac{(y-\mu)^2}{2\sigma^2}}\mathrm{d}y.$$

Consider the change of variables $z = (y-\mu)/\sigma$ so that we have

$$\mathbb{E}e^{\frac{\lambda}{2}(S-1)} = e^{\lambda/2\{\log(2\pi\sigma^2)\}}\frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi}}\int e^{\frac{\lambda}{2}[z^2-1]}e^{-z^2/2}\mathrm{d}y = e^{\lambda/2\{\log(2\pi\sigma^2)\}}\frac{e^{-2(\lambda/2)}}{\sqrt{1-2(\lambda/2)}}$$

for all $\lambda < 1$. Further, it can be verified that

$$\frac{e^{-\lambda/2}}{\sqrt{1-2(\lambda/2)}} \leq e^{\lambda^2/2}, \quad \forall|\lambda| < 1/2.$$

Hence, when we have $Y \sim N(\mu, \sigma^2)$, then $S = -\log f(Y)$ is sub-exponential with parameter $\nu = 1$ and $b = 2$. □

Therefore, to be able to apply extreme value theory to the surprisal values, we need a version of Lemma 3.1 that uses sub-exponentiality.

Lemma 3.3. *Suppose $\boldsymbol{y}_1, \ldots, \boldsymbol{y}_n$ are iid from a density f, and let $M_n = \max\{s_1, \ldots, s_n\}$ where $s_i = -\log f(\boldsymbol{y}_i)$. If Assumption 3.2 is satisfied, then, for $s \in \mathbb{R}_+$,*

$$\Pr(M_n - \mathbb{E}[S] \geq s) \leq 1 - \begin{cases} (1 - e^{-\frac{1}{2}s^2/\nu^2})^n & \text{if } 0 \leq s \leq \nu^2/b \\ (1 - e^{-s/2b})^n & \text{if } s > \nu^2/b \end{cases}.$$

Proof. The result follows a similar argument as for Lemma 3.1, up until we maximize the tail bound. In particular, for any $\lambda > 0$,

$$\begin{aligned} \Pr\{S - \mathbb{E}[S] \geq s\} = \Pr\left\{e^{\lambda(S-\mathbb{E}[S])} \geq e^{\lambda s}\right\} &\leq e^{-\lambda s}\mathbb{E}e^{\lambda(S-\mathbb{E}[S])} \\ &\leq e^{-\lambda s}e^{\lambda^2\nu^2/2}. \end{aligned}$$

Now, we must consider a constrained optimization to ensure the right-hand side exists. In particular, we know from the proof of Lemma 3.1 that the unconstrained optimum is $\lambda = s/\nu^2$, which corresponds to the constrained optimum on the set $0 \leq t < \nu^2/b$. However, when $s \geq \nu^2/b$, the maximum is achieved at $\lambda = 1/b$, and putting this together yields

$$\Pr\{S - \mathbb{E}[S] \geq s\} \leq \begin{cases} e^{-\frac{1}{2}s^2/\nu^2} & \text{if } 0 \leq s \leq \nu^2/b; \\ e^{-s/2b} & \text{if } s > \nu^2/b. \end{cases}$$

The stated result again follows by noting that

$$\begin{aligned} \Pr\{M_n - \mathbb{E}[S] \geq s\} &= 1 - \Pr\{M_n \leq s\} \\ &= 1 - \Pr\{S \leq s\}^n \\ &\leq 1 - \begin{cases} (1 - e^{-\frac{1}{2}s^2/\nu^2})^n & \text{if } 0 \leq s \leq \nu^2/b; \\ (1 - e^{-s/2b})^n & \text{if } s > \nu^2/b. \end{cases} \end{aligned}$$

□

Results similar to Lemma 3.3 also hold for $\Pr\{M_n - \mathbb{E}[S] \le s\}$, and for $\Pr\{|M_n - \mathbb{E}[S]| \ge s\}$ with an additional factor of 2, i.e.,

$$\Pr\{|M_n - \mathbb{E}[S]| \ge s\} \le 1 - \begin{cases} (1 - 2e^{-\frac{1}{2}s^2/v^2})^n & \text{if } 0 \le s \le v^2/b \\ (1 - 2e^{-s/2b})^n & \text{if } s > v^2/b. \end{cases}$$

Corollary 3.2. *Under Assumption 3.2, for $s > v^2/b$, as $n \to \infty$*

$$\Pr(|M_n - \mathbb{E}[S]| \ge (2b)s + (2b)\log(2n)) \le 1 - e^{-e^{-s}} + o(1/n).$$

Proof. Apply Assumption 3.2 to see that

$$\begin{aligned} \Pr(|M_n - \mathbb{E}[S]| \ge (2b)s + (2b)\log(2n)) &\le 1 - \left\{1 - 2e^{-[2bs + 2b\log(2n)]/2b}\right\}^n \\ &= 1 - \left(1 - e^{-s}/n\right)^n \\ &= 1 - e^{e^{-s}} - \left[\left(1 - e^{-s}/n\right)^n - e^{e^{-s}}\right]. \end{aligned}$$

The result now follows by noting that, for all $s > 0$,

$$\left[\left(1 - e^{-s}/n\right)^n - e^{e^{-s}}\right] = o(1) \le 0.$$

□

Corollary 3.2 is useful as it shows that if the surprisal has a sub-exponential tail, then the resulting maximum surprisal tail probability converges to that of an extreme value distribution. In particular, we have that Corollary 3.2 implies

$$\sup_{s:s>v^2/b} \left|\Pr\left\{|M_n - \mu| \ge \left[2bs + 2b\log(2n)\right]\right\} - \left(1 - e^{e^{-s}}\right)\right| = o(1).$$

To see that this implies that $M_n - \mathbb{E}[S]$, appropriately standardized, converges to an extreme value distribution, we first recall that

$$\Pr\{X_n > x\} - \Pr\{X > x\} = 1 - \Pr\{X_n \le x\} - [1 - \Pr\{X \le x\}] = \Pr\{X \le x\} - \Pr\{X_n \le x\}.$$

Hence,

$$\sup_{x\in\mathscr{X}} |\Pr\{X_n \le x\} - \Pr\{X \le x\}| = \sup_{x\in\mathscr{X}} |\Pr\{X_n > x\} - \Pr\{X > x\}|,$$

so that when X_n and X are both continuous we see that Corollary 3.2 implies that the CDF of $(M_n - \mathbb{E}[S] - 2b\log(2n))/2b$ converges to that of the Type-1 extreme value distribution (i.e., Gumbel distribution); i.e., using Corollary 3.2 and the above we have that

$$\sup_{s:s>v^2/b} \left| \Pr\left(|M_n - \mu| \le [2bs + 2b\log(2n)]\right\} - e^{e^{-s}} \right| = o(1).$$

This is one notion of convergence in distribution.

3.3 S has a polynomial moment

Finally, we consider the case where the surprisal has a polynomial moment (e.g., Student-t random variables), and derive a corresponding result to Lemma 3.1.

Suppose $\boldsymbol{y}_1, \ldots, \boldsymbol{y}_n$ are iid from a density f, and let $M_n = \max\{s_1, \ldots, s_n\}$ where $s_i = -\log f(\boldsymbol{y}_i)$. If Assumption 3.3 is satisfied, then, for $s > 0$ and such that $s > C > 0$,

$$\Pr\left(|M_n - \mathbb{E}[S]| \ge s\right) \le 1 - (1 - C^p/s^p)^n.$$

Hence,

$$\sup_{s:s>C} \left| \Pr\left(|M_n - \mathbb{E}[S]| \le (s \cdot n^{1/p})\right) - e^{-s^{-p}} \right| = o(1).$$

Proof. By Markov's inequality,

$$\Pr\{|S - \mathbb{E}[S]| \ge s\} \le \frac{\mathbb{E}|S|^p}{s^p} \le \frac{C^p}{s^p}.$$

To derive the first stated result, again note that

$$\begin{aligned}
\Pr\{|M_n - \mathbb{E}[S]| \ge s\} &= 1 - \Pr\{|M_n - \mathbb{E}[S]| \le s\} \\
&= 1 - \Pr\{|S - \mathbb{E}[S]| \le s\}^n \\
&= 1 - (1 - \Pr\{|S - \mathbb{E}[S]| \ge s\})^n \\
&\le 1 - (1 - C^p/s^p)^n.
\end{aligned}$$

To derive the second stated result, apply the first result with $t = sn^{1/p}C > 1$, which clearly holds for some n large enough, to see that

$$\Pr\{|M_n - \mathbb{E}[S]| \geq t\} \leq 1 - \left(1 - \frac{C^p}{(Csn^{1/p})^p}\right)^n = 1 - \left(1 - s^{-p}/n\right)^n.$$

Now, recall that, for $x \geq 0$,

$$\lim_{n\to\infty} (1 - x/n)^n = e^{-x}.$$

Since $x \mapsto e^{-x}$ is bounded for all $x \geq 0$, it follows that

$$\sup_{s:s>C} \left|\Pr\{|M_n - \mathbb{E}[S]| \geq t\} - e^{-s^{-p}}\right| = o(1).$$

□

3.4 Three types theorem

Placing the three lemmas together gives the following "three types" Theorem.

Theorem 3.1. *Let $\boldsymbol{y}_1, \ldots, \boldsymbol{y}_n$ be an iid sequence from F, and let $S = -\log f(\boldsymbol{Y})$, where $Y \sim \boldsymbol{F}$. Further, let $M_n = \max\{s_1, \ldots, s_n\}$, where $s_i = -\log f(y_i)$.*

1. *If the surprisal satisfies Assumption 3.1, then*

$$\sup_{s:s>0} \left|\Pr\left\{\left|M_n - \mathbb{E}[S]\right| \geq \sqrt{2v^2 s} + \sqrt{2v^2 \log(2n)}\right\} - e^{-s}\right| = o(1).$$

2. *If the surprisal satisfies Assumption 3.2, then*

$$\sup_{s:s>1/b} \left|\Pr\left\{\left|M_n - \mathbb{E}[S]\right| \geq (2b)s + (2b)\log(2n)\right\} - e^{-e^{-s}}\right| = o(1).$$

3. *If the surprisal satisfies Assumption 3.3, then*

$$\sup_{s:s>C} \left|\Pr\left\{\left|M_n - \mathbb{E}[S]\right| \geq (Csn^{1/p})\right\} - e^{-s^{-p}}\right| = o(1).$$

Theorem 3.1 gives a corresponding 'three types' theorem for the behavior of surprisals and has a simple interpretation. If the surprisal has Gaussian like tails, then the maximum surprisal is a reversed Weibull; if it only has an exponential moment, then the maximum surprisal will be Gumbel; if the maximum surprisal only has a polynomial moment, then it is Fréchet. As each of these distributions is a member of the generalized extreme value family, then the upper tail of the distribution can be approximated by a Generalized Pareto Distribution (Coles 2001, Theorem 4.1).

4 Experiments

4.1 Standard univariate normal values

Although we need to assume some density function f when computing surprisals, we want the resulting tail probabilities to be robust to a mis-specified distribution. Suppose we generate 1000 observations from a $N(0,1)$ distribution, but use a $t(4)$ distribution to compute the surprisal values. The empirical tail probabilities, and those obtained using the GPD approach, should still give reasonable estimates of the tail probabilities, despite the incorrect distribution being used to compute the surprisals.

To study the effect of the assumed distribution, we compute the surprisal values using both the correct Normal density and an incorrect $t(4)$ density. Then, for each set of surprisal values, we estimate the surprisal tail probabilities in three ways: (a) using the same distribution used to compute the surprisal values; (b) using empirical tail probabilities; and (c) using a GPD fitted to the largest 100 surprisal values.

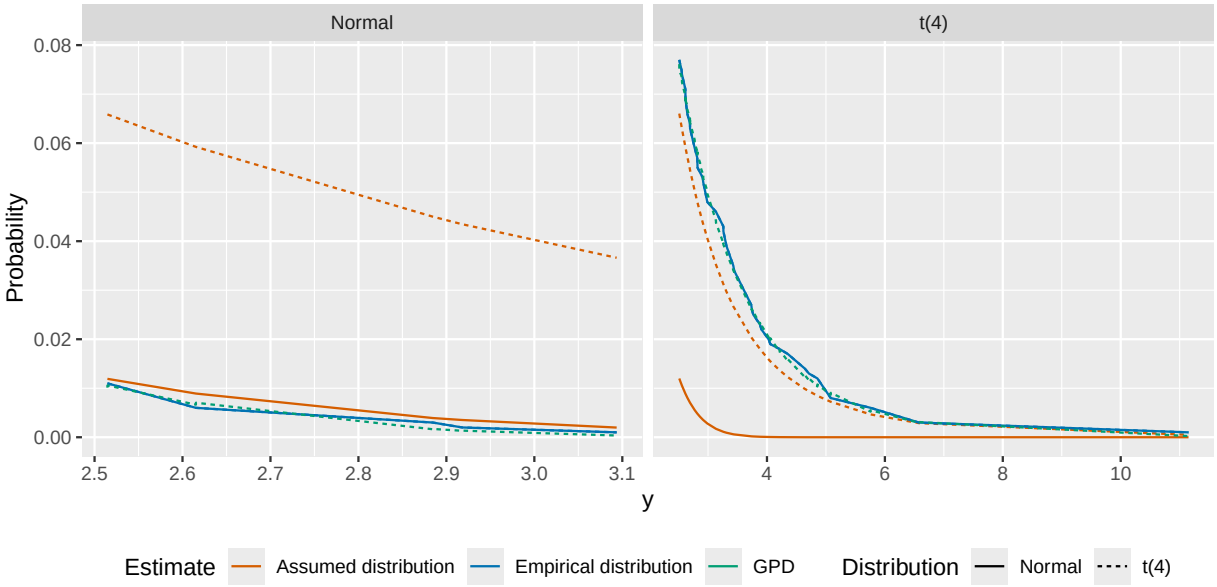


Figure 1: *Left: Observations are computed from a $\mathcal{N}(\iota, \infty)$ distribution. Right: Observations are computed from a $t(4)$ distribution. Distribution indicates which distribution was used to compute the surprisal values. Estimate shows how the tail probabilities were computed. This demonstrates that the surprisal probabilities computed using the empirical distribution or under the GPD are still relatively accurate, even when the wrong distribution is used to compute the surprisal values.*

The various estimates are displayed in the left panel of Figure 1 for observations greater than 2.5, showing how both empirical tail probabilities and the GPD estimates are still accurate, regardless of which distribution was used to compute the surprisals. The solid lines show the results for surprisals computed using the true $N(0,1)$ distribution, while the dashed line shows the results for surprisals

computed using the mis-specified $t(4)$ distribution. The estimates computed directly from $t(4)$ ("Assumed distribution") are very inaccurate, but all other estimates lie close to the truth.

In summary, even when we don't know the distribution of the data, we can use some incorrect assumed distribution to compute the surprisals, and then apply either a GPD or the empirical distribution to obtain good estimates of the surprisal probabilities.

The converse situation is shown in the right panel of Figure 1, where the data are generated from a $t(4)$ distribution, and the surprisal values are computed using both the correct $t(4)$ density and an incorrect $N(0,1)$ density. Again, the empirical tail probabilities, and the GPD estimates, are relatively accurate, even when the wrong distribution is used to compute the surprisal values.

4.2 Bivariate gamma values

The quality of the approximation used depends on the amount of data available, so in this next experiment we compare the tail probabilities of the different approaches across sample sizes. Let $\boldsymbol{Y} = (Y_{i,1}, Y_{i,2})'$ where $Y_{i,j}$ are independent Gamma(2,2) random variables. We generate n observations from this bivariate distribution, and explore the quality of the probability estimates as n increases from 100 to 100,000. The surprisal values are computed using the correct distribution, as well as the incorrect bivariate normal distribution with mean $(1,1)'$ and covariance matrix $0.5\boldsymbol{I}$. For each set of surprisal values, we estimate the tail probabilities in two ways: (a) using empirical tail probabilities; and (b) using a GPD fitted to the largest 10% of surprisal values. We repeat this experiment 1000 times for each sample size. The anomaly rate shown is the number of anomalies detected when $\alpha = 0.01$ for different sample sizes, averaged over 1000 replications. The false anomaly rate under the true distribution is, of course, 0.01.

Note that the empirical tail probabilities are identical under both the correct Gamma and incorrect Normal distributions, because the ranking of the surprisals in the tail are unchanged.

> **!** Important
>
> What's going on with the GPD under Gaussian? There seems to be an asymptotic bias.

5 Applications

5.1 French mortality rates

French mortality rates, disaggregated by age (single years) and sex, are available from the Human Mortality Database (2025). We will consider male and female data from 1816 to 1999 over ages 0 to 85, giving 172 separate time series, each of length 184.

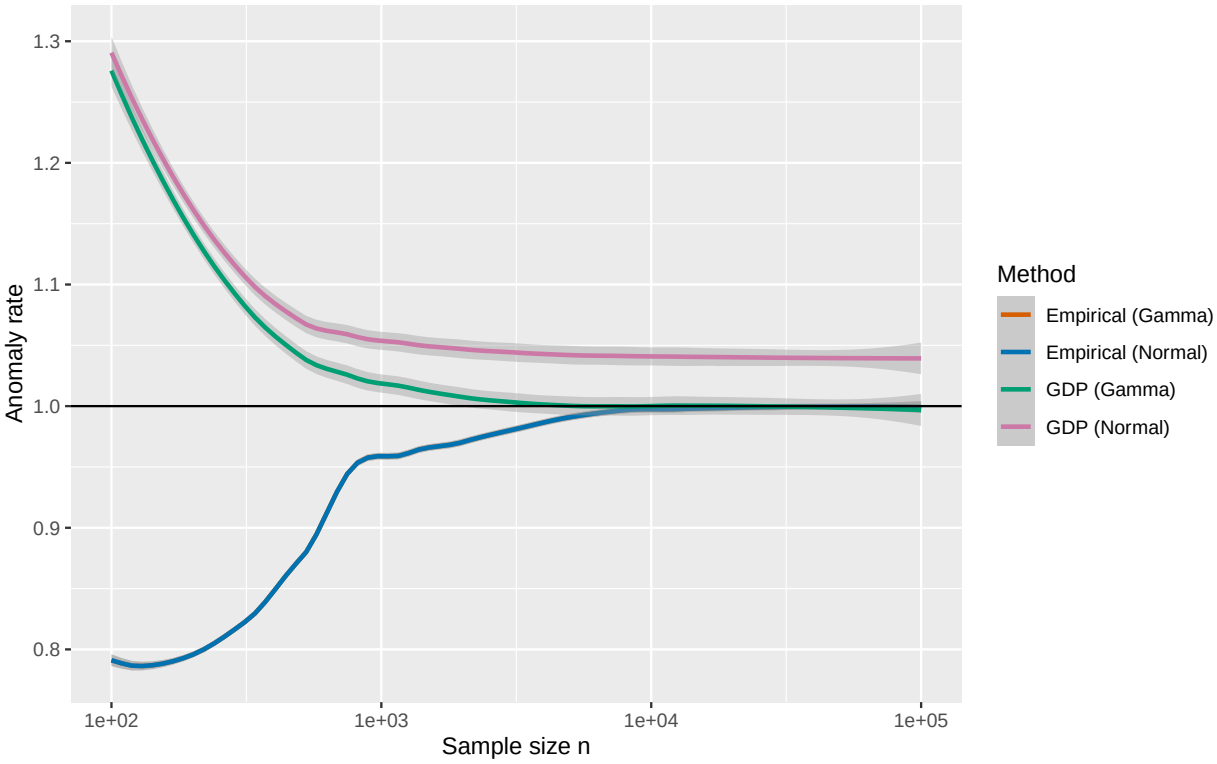


Figure 2: *Estimated false anomaly rate under different approximations when* $\alpha = 0.01$.

Figure 3 shows the data for both sexes and all ages. The mortality rates have improved over time for all ages, especially since 1950. Infant mortality (age 0) is much higher than the rest of childhood, with mortality rates at a minimum at about age 10 in all years. The highest mortality rates are for the oldest age groups. The effect of the two wars are particularly evident in the male mortality rates.

We compute the surprisals using the conditional distribution (1), and then compute the surprisal probabilities under a GPD with $\alpha = 0.01$. With so many observations, there is a high likelihood of many false positives, so we only retain anomalies when at least three age groups are anomalous in the same year, and for the same sex. This results in 289 anomalies out of 31648 observations. Figure 4 shows these anomalies, which coincide with various wars and epidemics that have occurred over French history:

- 1832, 1849: Cholera outbreaks
- 1870: Franco–Prussian war
- 1871: Repression of the ‘Commune de Paris’
- 1914-1918: World War I
- 1918: Spanish flu outbreak
- 1940: World War II

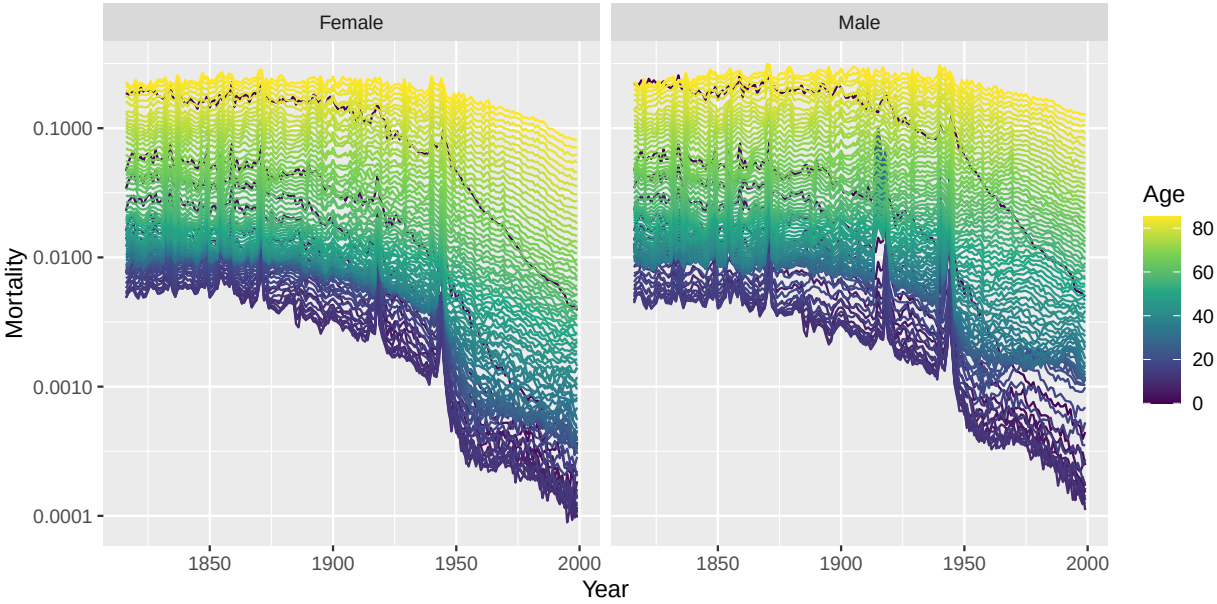


Figure 3: *French mortality rates by sex and age from 1816 to 1999. We use a log scale because the rates are vastly different for different age groups.*

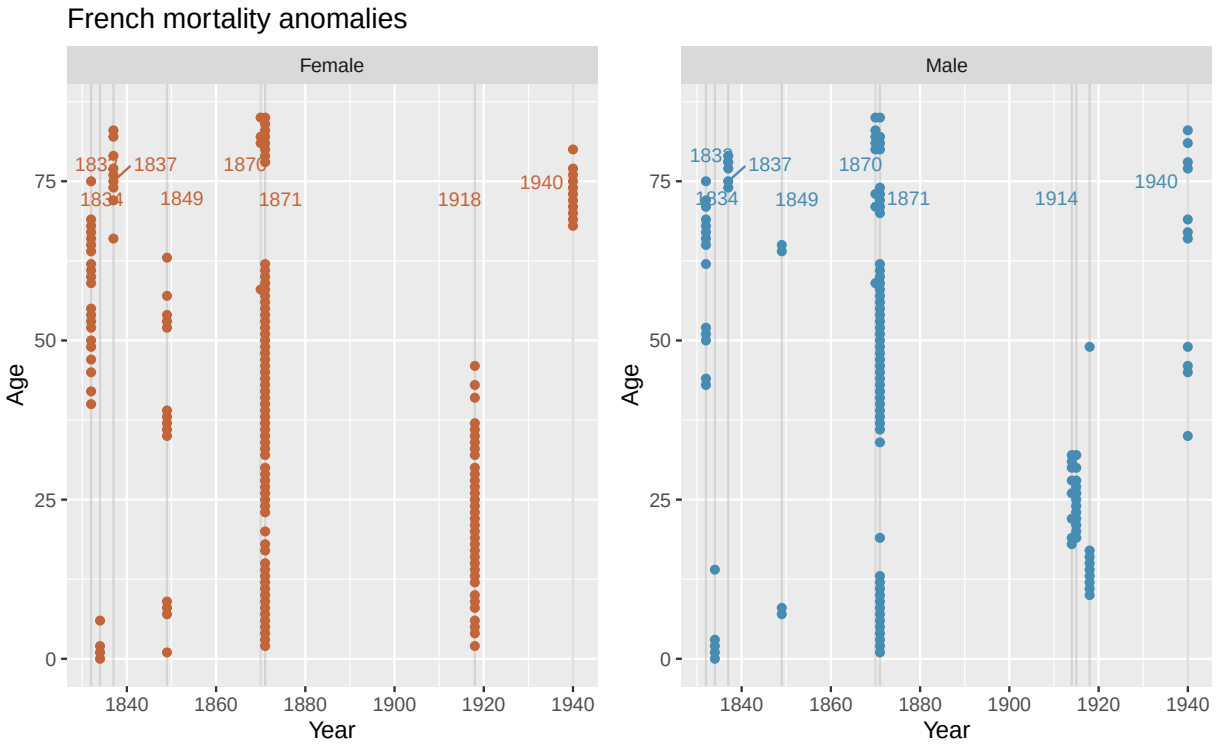


Figure 4: *Anomalies identified in the Frency mortality data by year and age. Wars and epidemics in French history are revealed.*

In addition, there appears to have been unusually high infant mortality in 1834, and unusually high elderly mortality in 1837. The causes of these is unknown.

5.2 Test cricket not outs

Career batting data for all men and women to have played test cricket between 1834 and 6 October 2025 were obtained from Hyndman (2025). We will investigate if there are some batters who have an unusually high proportion of innings where they have not been dismissed, known as a "not out". The data set contains results from 97649 innings, of which 12695 were not outs. So the overall proportion of not outs is $12695/97649 = 0.130$.

Figure 5 shows the proportion of not outs for each batter as a function of the number of innings they played. The unusual patterns on the left of each plot are due to the discrete nature of the data — both the number of not outs and the number of innings must be integers. There is some overplotting that occurs due to batters having the same numbers of not-outs and innings, which results in the higher color density of the corresponding plotted points. Batters who have played only a few innings tend to have a higher proportion of not outs on average, and a higher variance, than those who have played many innings.

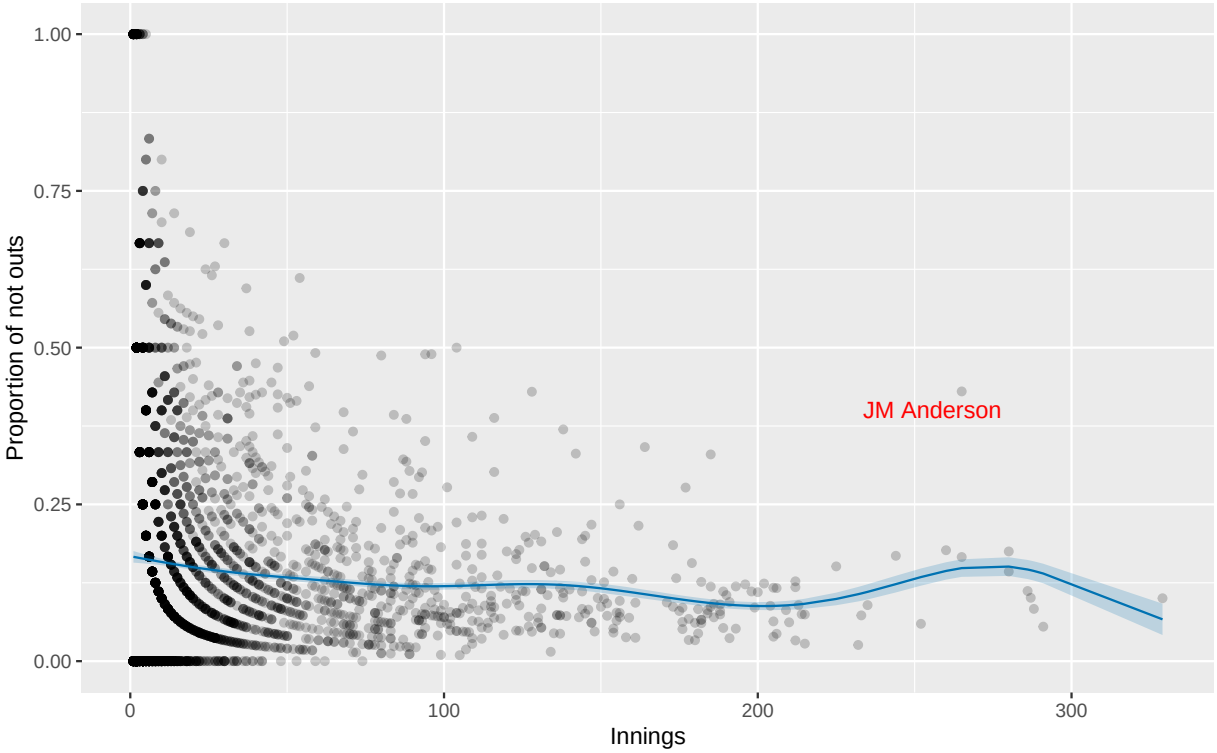


Figure 5: *Proportion of not outs for each batter as a function of the number of innings they played. The blue line and associated 95% confidence interval shows the probability of a batter not being dismissed as a function of the number of innings they have played.*

This suggests that we can construct a generalized additive model (Wood 2017) for the number of not outs for each batter as a function of the number of innings they played. It is natural to use a Binomial distribution with a logit link function:

$$\text{NotOuts} \mid \text{Innings} \sim \text{Binomial}(n = \text{Innings},\ p),$$

where p denotes the probability of a batter not being dismissed in an innings,

$$\log(p/(1-p)) = g(\text{Innings}),$$

and $g()$ is a smooth function to be estimated nonparametrically. The resulting estimate, obtained from the mgcv package with penalized regression splines (Wood 2025), is shown in blue in Figure 5.

Now we can use the fitted model to compute the surprisals from the Binomial distribution, and find the most anomalous batters. While the Binomial distribution is probably a good first approximation, it does assume that the probability of a batter being dismissed does not change over their career, which is an unlikely assumption as it does not allow for the development of skill, the value of experience, or the effect of aging. So we will use the GPD approximation to compute the surprisal probabilities.

The most anomalous batters are all "tail-enders" (i.e., not skilled batters) who played for a long time (so they have many innings). Because they batted last, or nearly last, they are more likely to be not out at the end of the team's innings.

The largest surprisal is for English batter Jimmy Anderson, who has had 114 not outs in 265 innings, which is much higher than the expected number of not outs of $265 \times 0.148 = 39.3$. This anomaly is also seen in Figure 5, as being somewhat unusual for that part of the data. Although Jimmy Anderson was not a great batter, he was good at defense, and was able to bat for a long time without being dismissed, leaving the other batter time to score runs.

We have identified an anomaly that is not anomalous in the proportion of not-outs, or in the number of innings, and the difference between the actual proportion and the predicted proportion is not anomalous either compared to some of the other values. However, because we have used a statistical model, we have been able to account for the particular features of this data set, such as the discrete nature of the data, and the changing variance, to identify an observation that is anomalous in the context of the model.

6 Discussion

Software and reproducibility

All results presented here can be reproduced using the code available at https://github.com/robjhyndman/Surprisal_Theory. The analysis was conducted using R version 4.5.1 (R Core Team 2025), with the following R packages: weird (Hyndman 2025), tsibble (Wang et al. 2025), targets (Landau 2025, 2021), ggplot2 (Wickham et al. 2025; Wickham 2016), and other tidyverse (Wickham et al. 2019) packages.

Acknowledgements

Both authors are funded by the Australian Research Council through Discovery Project DP250100702. Rob Hyndman is a member of the Australian Research Council Industrial Transformation Training Centre in Optimisation Technologies, Integrated Methodologies, and Applications (OPTIMA), Project ID IC200100009.

References

Coles, S (2001). *An introduction to statistical modeling of extreme values*. Vol. 208. Springer Series in Statistics. London UK: Springer.

Cover, TM & JA Thomas (2006). *Elements of information theory*. 2nd. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley.

Davies, L & U Gather (1, 1993). The Identification of Multiple Outliers. *Journal of the American Statistical Association* **88** (423), 782–792.

Good, IJ (1952). Rational decisions. *Journal of the Royal Statistical Society. Series B, Statistical methodology* **14** (1), 107–114.

Grubbs, FE (1950). Sample Criteria for Testing Outlying Observations. en. *Annals of Mathematical Statistics* **21**(1), 27–58.

Human Mortality Database (2025). *University of California, Berkeley (USA); Max Planck Institute for Demographic Research (Germany)*. Accessed on 6 October 2025. www.mortality.org.

Hyndman, RJ (1996). Computing and graphing highest density regions. *The American Statistician* **50**(2), 120–126.

Hyndman, RJ (2025). *weird: Functions and Data Sets for "That's Weird: Anomaly Detection Using R" by Rob J Hyndman*. Version 1.0.2,9000. https://pkg.robjhyndman.com/weird-package/.

Hyndman, RJ, S Kandanaarachchi & K Turner (2025). *When lookout sees crackle: Anomaly detection via kernel density estimation*. Tech. rep. Monash University.

Kandanaarachchi, S & RJ Hyndman (2022). Leave-one-out kernel density estimates for outlier detection. *J Computational & Graphical Statistics* **31** (2), 586–599.

Landau, WM (2021). The targets R package: a dynamic Make-like function-oriented pipeline toolkit for reproducibility and high-performance computing. *Journal of Open Source Software* **6**(57), 2959.

Landau, WM (2025). *targets: Dynamic Function-Oriented 'Make'-Like Declarative Pipelines*. Version v1.11.3. https://cran.r-project.org/package=targets.

R Core Team (2025). *R: A Language and Environment for Statistical Computing*. R Foundation for Statistical Computing. Vienna, Austria. https://www.R-project.org/.

Stone, JV (2022). *Information theory: a tutorial introduction*. Sheffield, England: Sebtel Press.

Tribus, M (1961). *Thermodynamics and Thermostatics: An Introduction to Energy, Information and States of Matter, with Engineering Applications*. New York, USA: D. Van Nostrand.

Wang, E, D Cook, RJ Hyndman, M O'Hara-Wild, T Smith & W Davis (2025). *tsibble: Tidy Temporal Data Frames and Tools*. Version 1.1.6. https://tsibble.tidyverts.org.

Wickham, H (2016). *ggplot2: Elegant Graphics for Data Analysis*. New York, USA: Springer-Verlag. https://ggplot2-book.org/.

Wickham, H, M Averick, J Bryan, W Chang, LD McGowan, R François, G Grolemund, A Hayes, L Henry, J Hester, M Kuhn, TL Pedersen, E Miller, SM Bache, K Müller, J Ooms, D Robinson, DP Seidel, V Spinu, K Takahashi, D Vaughan, C Wilke, K Woo & H Yutani (2019). Welcome to the tidyverse. *Journal of Open Source Software* **4**(43), 1686.

Wickham, H, W Chang, L Henry, TL Pedersen, K Takahashi, C Wilke, K Woo, H Yutani, D Dunnington, T van den Brand & Posit, PBC (2025). *ggplot2: Create Elegant Data Visualisations Using the Grammar of Graphics*. Version v3.5.2. https://cran.r-project.org/package=ggplot2.

Wilkinson, L (2018). Visualizing Big Data Outliers Through Distributed Aggregation. *IEEE Transactions on Visualization and Computer Graphics* **24**(1), 256–266.

Wood, SN (2017). *Generalized additive models: an introduction with R*. CRC press.

Wood, SN (2025). *Mixed GAM Computation Vehicle with Automatic Smoothness Estimation*. Version v1.9-3. https://cran.r-project.org/package=mgcv.